

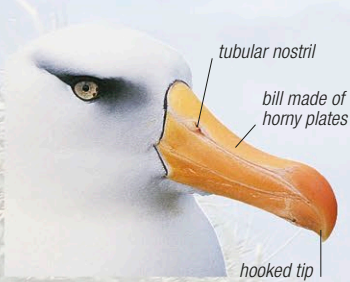
Albatrosses and petrels

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Procellariiformes
FAMILIES	4
SPECIES	147

Albatrosses and their relatives are oceanic birds that occur throughout the world. They are usually encountered far from land, flying low over waves or dipping into the water to feed on fish, plankton, or various other marine animals. Besides the very large albatrosses, this group includes the smaller fulmars, gadfly petrels, and shearwaters, as well as the tiny storm petrels and diving petrels. All members of the group have tubular nostrils on their upper bill—a unique feature among birds; as a result, they are often known as tubenoses.

Anatomy

Albatrosses and their relatives have a short neck, tail, and legs. The front 3 toes are joined by webbing. Most species have very long wings; the wandering albatross, with a wingspan of 11 ft (3.5 m), has the longest wingspan recorded for any bird. Another notable feature of birds in this group is their exceptionally acute sense of smell, which they use to detect food and locate nest sites in the dark. It is thought that each bird may exude its own particular scent.



ALBATROSS BILL
Birds in this group have a bill with a hooked tip and sharp blades for dealing with slippery prey. Albatrosses differ from other species in having nostrils positioned on either side of the upper bill rather than being fused into one on the top (see left).

Reproduction

All birds in this group breed on land, mostly on inaccessible islands or cliffs. They return each year to established breeding sites, where they form large colonies of up to a million pairs. The female always lays a single egg, often in a burrow dug in soft soil or in rock crevices. After a long incubation, the parents feed the chick on their highly nutritious but foul-smelling stomach oil.



BREEDING COLONY
Like other birds in the group, fulmars often form dense colonies in safe, inaccessible places. Many species visit the colony only after dark, as protection against predators.

SOARING

The long wings of this black-browed albatross are adapted for extended soaring, often for hours on end without a wingbeat.

Flight

These ocean-going birds are adapted to continuous flight, often traveling great distances and riding out powerful storms. Their flight method varies according to the bird's size and wingspan. The larger species, including the albatrosses, typically glide rather than fly, making use of the updrafts of wind over waves to give them lift for long periods without expending too much energy (a practice known as dynamic soaring). The tiny, lightweight storm petrels fly with a combination of wingbeats and glides.



FINDING FOOD

Storm petrels fly low over water in search of food. Some species patter on the surface with their feet to alarm their prey or draw it toward the surface.

Diomedea exulans

Wandering albatross



Location Circumpolar around Antarctica

Length	3½ ft (1.1 m)
Weight	18–25 lb (8–11.5 kg)
Plumage	Sexes alike
Migration	Migrant
Status	Vulnerable



This albatross has a wingspan of up to 11 ft (3.5 m), one of the largest of any bird. It feeds mainly at the surface, primarily on squid. It breeds only every other year (at best), since rearing a chick takes a year, and molts in the intervening year. These birds are in decline because they often get caught on baited hooks used in long-line fishing for fish such as tuna.

PAIRED FOR LIFE

Albatrosses are monogamous and the male–female bond is very strong. An elaborate courtship display, involving much posturing, head shaking, beak snapping, and ritualized preening is usually initiated by the female.

NESTING

This albatross' nest is a crude but substantial mound of grasses and moss, built on the ground. The parents take turns to incubate the solitary egg. Once it has hatched, they tend their chick for 9 months or more.



Thalassarche chlororhynchos

Atlantic yellow-nosed albatross



Location South Atlantic

Length	30 in (76 cm)
Weight	5½ lb (2.5 kg)
Plumage	Sexes alike
Migration	Migrant
Status	Endangered



The smallest albatross in the southern ocean, this black and white species takes its name from the yellow ridge and orange tip on its black bill. Squid and fish make up the bulk of its diet, but it also follows ships, feeding on offal thrown overboard. Both parents rear the chick, which is able to fly relatively quickly for an albatross—within about 4 months.

